

PRASHANT PANJIAR



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RAGHU RAI

IN SEARCH OF PEACE (Clockwise from top) Rajiv with US president Ronald Reagan on a 1985 visit; with Sri Lanka president J. Jayawardene, 1987; with Pakistan PM Benazir Bhutto at a SAARC summit in Islamabad, 1988; and with Chinese leader Deng Xiaoping, 1988

munal question. His chance to make a bold choice came early, in 1985, as the Supreme Court ruled in favour of 67-year-old Shah Bano Begum's right to alimony from a husband who had divorced her in old age. It became a cause célèbre: Shah Bano's kohl-lined eyes and set jaws were all over the national press. But where the poor Muslim woman from Indore displayed a will of steel in defying her community's clerics, the posh Doon School alum chose abject surrender. A law in Parliament nullified the verdict.

To this day, his Shah Bano decision is invoked as a convincing exemplar of 'Muslim appeasement'. Soon, that blunder would beget a greater blunder. Facing an avalanche of criticism from the BJP, Rajiv overcorrected to make amends, this time erring on the other side. Early in 1986, he green-lit the unlocking of the Babri Masjid, overturning a 1949 decision by his grandfather. Once the levee broke, the waters gushed in—four decades later, his party is yet to recover.

On foreign policy, he was thrust into a difficult transitional time, marked by legacy problems. As a fourth generation Nehru-Gandhi, with an unfinished sortie to Cambridge to boot, Rajiv was at ease with the world. But the neighbourhood was already fraught: Pakistan had its fingerprints all over Punjab, India too was a covert actor in the Sri Lankan civil war. But at least after Operation Brasstacks in 1986-87, he showed a rare willingness to break the mould.

In Benazir Bhutto, he found a near-mirror image: young, foreign-educated dynast. Their dialogue yielded the Non-Nuclear Aggression Agreement, which is still in force. His historic 1988 China visit thawed long-frosty ties, delivering the equally durable Joint Working Group on borders. The Six-Nation Initiative with Swedish PM and friend Olof Palme—both stalked by the Bofors stain and, in the end, by assassins—took his pacifism further afield. But when he sued for peace in Sri Lanka, it's war that caught up with him. The IPKF misadventure became the prelude to a bloody end. ■